

Funding Proposal: MScAC Ski Trip

Executive Summary

We propose a one-day ski and snowboard trip to Blue Mountain Resort on Saturday, March 7, 2026. Organized in partnership with the University of Toronto Ski and Snowboard Club (UTSSC), this event will bring together MScAC students for a full day on the slopes, offering a meaningful opportunity for cohort bonding, physical recreation, and cultural engagement mid-winter semester. We request **\$2,760** to fully subsidize the bus and lift ticket for up to 20 MScAC student participants.

Event Description

The MScAC Ski Trip will transport students by coach bus from Convocation Hall to Blue Mountain Resort in Collingwood, Ontario — approximately a 2-hour drive from Toronto. UTSSC has reserved 20 seats on their chartered bus for MScAC students and has negotiated group-rate lift tickets on behalf of all participants. Upon arrival, students receive their lift tickets (and rentals or a beginner lesson, if selected) and spend the day skiing or snowboarding at their own pace, with UTSSC mentors available to guide first-timers. The coach bus returns all attendees to campus by approximately 7:30 PM.

Event Goals and Benefits

Physical wellness and recreation. A mid-winter trip to the slopes gives students a meaningful break from academic demands during a period when stress typically peaks.

Community building. Shared adventure outside the classroom is one of the most effective mechanisms for cohort bonding. A full day on the mountain — travelling together, encouraging beginners, and unwinding after a day on the slopes — creates strong connections across the cohort.

Cultural engagement. For many international students, skiing and snowboarding are entirely new experiences. This trip provides exposure to a Canadian winter tradition in a safe, organized setting with experienced peers, removing the barrier of not knowing where to begin.

Accessibility and inclusion. Centralizing transportation eliminates the need for a car or local knowledge of resort logistics — both significant barriers for international students. The MScAC subsidy further reduces the cost barrier for what is otherwise an expensive activity, ensuring financial constraints do not prevent interested students from attending.

Resource Requirements

Tax included in all prices where applicable.

Item	Unit Cost	Qty	Total
Bus subsidy (per MScAC student)	\$45.00	20	\$900.00

Item	Unit Cost	Qty	Total
Lift ticket subsidy (per MScAC student, group rate)	\$93.00	20	\$1,860.00
Total Requested			\$2,760.00

Additional optional participant costs (not subsidized): ski/snowboard rentals (\$80.00), beginner lesson with UTSSC mentor (\$49.95). Participants who bring their own gear pay nothing beyond the subsidized bus and lift ticket.

Resource and Itinerary Rationale

Blue Mountain Resort in Collingwood is the closest major ski resort to Toronto (~150 km, ~2 hours), making it the natural choice for a same-day trip. It supports a full range of terrain for beginners and intermediate skiers, has an accredited ski school, and comfortably accommodates large groups. UTSSC has an established relationship with Blue Mountain and has organized group trips there previously.

Coach bus transportation is necessary as Blue Mountain is inaccessible by public transit. The bus has already been booked and is managed entirely by UTSSC, including all logistics and cancellation terms — this eliminates organizational risk for the MScAC side of the event. UTSSC has reserved 20 seats specifically for MScAC students.

The lift ticket rate of \$93 is a UTSSC-negotiated group discount, below standard student walk-up pricing. No further comparison shopping is needed as UTSSC's established group rate is the best available for organized student groups of this size.

Implementation

Schedule (March 7, 2026)

Time	Activity
7:45 AM	Bus loading begins at Convocation Hall
8:00 AM	Bus departs (on time — late arrivals cannot be accommodated)
10:00–10:30 AM	Arrive at Blue Mountain; lift and rental tickets distributed
10:30 AM – 4:45 PM	Free skiing, snowboarding, and optional lessons
4:45 PM	All participants return to bus
5:00 PM	Bus departs Blue Mountain
~7:30 PM	Arrive back in Toronto

Timeline

Milestone	Date
MScAC funding confirmed	Wednesday, February 25
UTSSC (Nicole) prepares MScAC-specific signup form	Wednesday February 25 – Thursday February 26
Subsidized signup link distributed to MScAC students	Friday, February 27
Registration and payment deadline	Sunday, March 1, 2026 at 5:00 PM
Tyler pays UTSSC; requests invoice	Saturday March 1 evening – Sunday March 2
MScAC reimburses Tyler	Post-trip
Event day	Saturday, March 7, 2026

Notes

- Once funding is confirmed, UTSSC will activate a dedicated sign-up link for MScAC students with the subsidy already applied, so students pay only for optional add-ons (rentals, lessons) at registration.
- After signups close on March 1, Tyler will pay UTSSC the lump sum ($\$138 \times \text{actual registrants}$) and request an invoice or receipt for reimbursement purposes. MScAC will reimburse Tyler following the trip.
- The subsidy applies to the first 20 MScAC registrants. Based on initial interest polling (~20) and current RSVP data (~15 confirmed), it is unlikely that demand will exceed 20. A fixed per-person subsidy was chosen over a dynamic model to allow the price to be set before registration opens.
- Bus logistics, including any necessary cancellation, are handled entirely by UTSSC. MScAC has no direct bus vendor liability.
- Tyler will serve as MScAC point-of-contact on the day and will coordinate with UTSSC if any participant requires early departure (e.g., due to injury).

Risk Management

Weather. Blue Mountain has extensive snowmaking infrastructure and typically guarantees skiing conditions through March. In the unlikely event of resort closure, UTSSC will handle communication and refund logistics.

Participant screening. The MScAC registration flow will collect emergency contact information, relevant medical conditions, and health insurance coverage. Participants are expected to self-assess their ability level before selecting activities.

Financial risk. Bus booking and cancellation logistics are managed by UTSSC. The UTSSC registration form offers refunds until 5:00 PM on Sunday March 1 — the same date as the MScAC registration deadline — after which no refunds are available. The fixed-per-head subsidy model ensures MScAC’s maximum exposure is capped at \$2,760 regardless of final attendance.

Safety

UTSSC safety infrastructure. UTSSC is an established U of T club with three designated Directors of Safety and Well-being and a formal trip safety policy. They provide all participants with an Emergency Response Contact package on trip day, which includes ski patrol numbers and the address and phone numbers of the nearest hospitals and health clinics. Blue Mountain Resort also operates a full-time ski patrol accessible at the top and bottom of every lift. This existing framework means MScAC does not need to independently staff or operate a safety program for this event.

Helmets. UTSSC policy mandates that all participants wear a helmet during any on-hill activity. This requirement will be communicated to MScAC participants at registration.

Beginner support. UTSSC offers a “Ski With Buddies” program that pairs participants by skill level, available to MScAC students through the registration form. An optional structured beginner lesson (\$49.95) is also available. Both options provide meaningful support for first-time skiers and snowboarders.

Group coordination. All participants will receive Tyler’s contact information and a clear 4:45 PM return-to-bus time. In the event of a participant injury, Tyler will serve as the MScAC point of contact and will coordinate with UTSSC’s safety team to facilitate resort assistance or early departure as needed.

Participant waiver. All participants registering through UTSSC’s form agree to a comprehensive Ontario-law assumption-of-risk and release-of-liability waiver, which explicitly names the University of Toronto as a releasee alongside UTSSC. This waiver covers all skiing and snowboarding activities and transportation and is binding on heirs and executors. As an optional supplement, MScAC participants may be asked to complete a brief acknowledgment form to collect emergency contacts and health information for Tyler’s awareness on trip day.